Disparities in Social Security and Medicaid Program Participation among Same-sex vs Different-sex Couples: Evidence from COVID-19 Pandemic Shocks

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INTRODUCTION

The growing proportion of individuals identifying as LGBTQ+ as well as disparities in equity of access to assistance programs highlights the need for data-driven insights into LGBTQ+ and non-LGBTQ+ individuals. Due to the identification strategy, LGBTQ+ and non-LGTBQ+ are analyzed by proxy through same-sex and different-sex couples, respectively. This study provides key insights into the demographic and socioeconomic make-up of same-sex vs different-sex couples, as well disparities in participation rates of Supplemental Security Income (SSI), Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) and Medicaid between same-sex and different-sex couples. Analysis from this study is important for the creation of effective policy and provides the basis for future research into this area.

RESEARCH QUESTION

What disparities in SSI, SSDI and Medicaid rates exist among same-sex and different sex couples? What happens to trends after shocks from the COVID-19 pandemic?

METHODS

Data

- American Community Survey 2017-2023
- Nationally representative, 3.5 million households annually

Identification

- Identify cohabitating couples by gender
  - No SOGI data
- Adjustments for accuracy of same-sex couples

Panel

- Observe groups based on weighted averages over period
- Demographics , socioeconomic, household, health indicators

Timeseries

- Analyze trends pre and post COVID-19 Shocks
  - Disability rates
  - SSDI, SSI, Medicaid

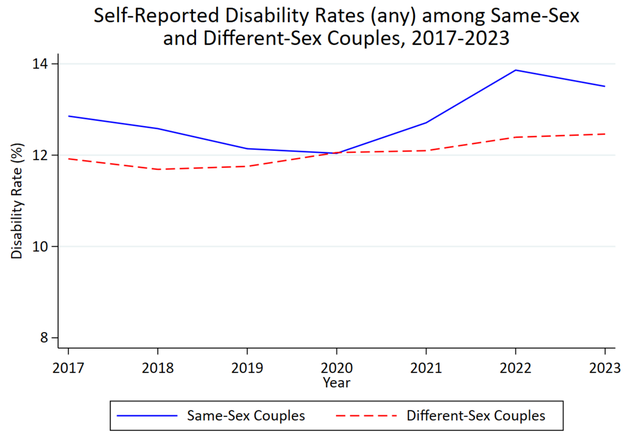
ANALYSIS

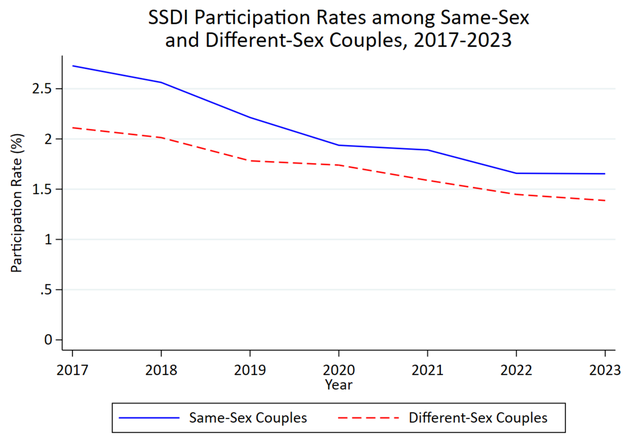
Demographic, Socioeconomic and Health Indicators

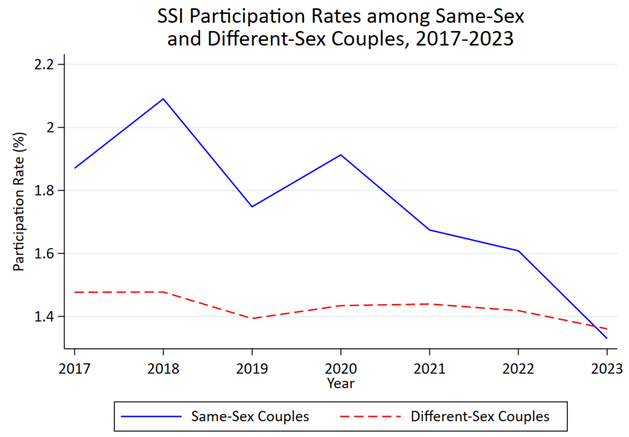
	Same - Sex	Different - Sex
Age	45.53	50.85
White	0.67	0.69
Black	0.09	0.08
Asian	0.04	0.06
Other	0.15	0.12
Hispanic	0.16	0.15
Married	0.60	0.88
Unmarried couple	0.40	0.12
Number of children in household	0.30	0.96
Homeowner	0.64	0.77
Employed	0.75	0.66
Median household income	105000.00	95400.00
Bachelor's degree or higher	0.49	0.39
Master's degree or higher	0.23	0.16
Any health insurance	0.93	0.93
Medicaid	0.10	0.10
Any disability	0.13	0.12

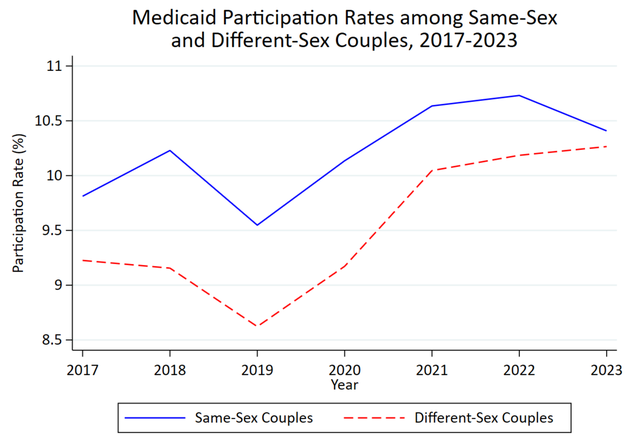
On average in this period, **same-sex couples:**

- Are younger by 5 years
- More racially diverse
- Less likely to be married
- Have one third as many kids
- Have higher levels of education, employment and median household income
- Report higher rates of disability









Supplemental Figures and Tables

CONCLUSIONS

- Same-sex couples show **higher rates** of disability, as well as SSDI, SSI and Medicaid participation
- General trends persist throughout the period **for both groups**
  - **Social Security** usage **decreases**
  - **Medicaid** usage **increases**
- **Differences shrink** post COVID-19 shocks
  - Same-sex couples see **larger reduction in Social Security participation**
    - Medicaid usage **peaks and begins declining** by 2023
- Indication of potential **shift from Social Security to Medicaid**

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